

power. We don't compromise ideology for power, Nitish does. It's hypocrisy to talk about secularism and then join hands with the BJP. Nitish wanted to retain his support among the extremely backward classes (EBCs). He was uncomfortable with the RJD's growing popularity among them. Leaders come and go but people are moving towards I.N.D.I.A.

Q. In West Bengal, the Congress-TMC alliance did not materialise because of Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury's personal issues with CM Mamata Banerjee. As Congress president, why didn't you rein him in, in the larger interests of the party?

We tried, but it did not work out. We are still trying. There is still time left for nominations. Wherever possible, we will try to make adjustments.

Q. PM Modi has converted the Lok Sabha polls into a presidential-style election. Critics say a primary weakness of the Opposition is that it has failed to project a strong face against Modi.

We are contesting the election as an alliance. Once we reach a position to form the government, we will decide who becomes prime minister. It has happened in the past too, during Morarji Desai, V.P. Singh and Deve Gowda's time.

Q. But most pollsters say people vote based on the leadership. Don't you think not having a PM face is a handicap?

From my experience of over 50 years in politics, I can say that people vote on ideology.

Q. What is the ideological battle you are fighting?

Our ideology is simple—the poor must progress. Under Modi, the rich are getting richer, the poor are getting poorer. There is massive unemployment, inflation is high. The last two elections were won on the strength of their propaganda. But people can now see through the falsehoods in it. The BJP keeps asking: what happened in the last 70 years? If nothing had happened in the last 70 years, we would not have seen so much progress in the country today. Did India get Independence only in 2014? Modi first started with the RSS agenda—save Hinduism. Slowly he kept that agenda aside and made everything about Modi. It's now all about saving Modi, Modi's guarantees. The PM only talks about himself. He doesn't talk about the party, its principles. This reflects his arrogance. People will teach him a lesson.

> "AS FOR ELECTORAL BONDS, THE BJP'S MEANS OF FUNDS COLLECTION IS DACOITY, WE HAVE TO BEG FOR FUNDS

> AMIT SHAH PUNISHES ANYONE WHO MAKES EVEN A SMALL MISTAKE. IN UTTAR PRADESH, CM YOGI ADITYANATH USES THE BULLDOZER"

Q. You talk about ideology. But the Congress, which demanded a probe against Arvind Kejriwal in the liquor policy case, has now joined hands with him. How do you explain this contradiction?

We are fighting for a cause, not an individual. We are not against investigation into corruption, but it should follow the laws of the land. We are fighting against the systematic dismantling of democratic norms by the Modi government. Anyone can be a beneficiary of this fight. We are asking Modi to follow the Constitution and provide good governance. But he is taking the law into his hands and putting opponents in jail. He is destroying the basic principles of the Constitution.

Q. The Congress has been raising the issue of electoral bonds. But your party has also taken donations through these bonds.

The Congress is not in power. We cannot coerce people to donate. They are contributing to us on their own goodwill. But how did the BJP collect funds? By giving contracts in exchange. By granting favours. By arresting people.